Handova

An initiative of **Ethical Bridge**

TRUST & SAFETY · POLICY AND PROCEDURE

Safeguarding Policy and Procedure

Children, adults at risk, and protection from sexual exploitation, abuse and harassment

How Handova keeps the people organisations serve, and everyone using the platform, safe from harm.

Version 1.0 | Approved 20 October 2026
Handova, an initiative of Ethical Bridge LLC

Skills handed over.
Capability that stays.

DOCUMENT CONTROL

About this document

DOCUMENT	Handova Safeguarding Policy and Procedure
TYPE	Policy and procedure
OWNER	Julieta Castiñeira de Dios
APPROVED BY	Julieta Castiñeira de Dios, founder, for Ethical Bridge LLC
VERSION	1.0
DATE OF APPROVAL	20 October 2026
NEXT REVIEW	October 2027, or sooner when Handova has a team, after a serious incident or when the law changes
APPLIES TO	Professionals, organisations and their focal points, the Handova team and anyone acting for Handova
OPERATOR	Handova is an initiative of Ethical Bridge LLC, registered in Wyoming, USA
CONTACT	safeguarding@handova.org · hello@handova.org
LANGUAGE	English

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PROPORTIONATE TO OUR SIZE

Handova is in its early stage. Today one person, the founder, runs both Handova and Ethical Bridge. This is our first version: it sets out what we do now and who does it. We will expand it as Handova grows and builds a team with dedicated safeguarding and compliance roles. Until then:

- **The founder is the safeguarding and privacy lead.** She receives reports, decides on protective action and keeps the records described here.
- **An independent contact** handles any concern about the founder, or that the founder is involved in, and covers urgent cases when the founder can't be reached for more than 48 hours. This is a trusted person outside Handova and Ethical Bridge: **to be confirmed soon**. They don't run Handova or investigate alone: they receive the concern, make sure it is handled fairly and get outside advice when needed.
- **We review this policy** at least once a year, as soon as Handova has a team, and after any serious incident.

AT A GLANCE

- **Remote only, no contact.** Professionals never contact, meet or message the people an organisation serves.
- **Anonymous by default.** Professionals do not see identifiable personal data about the people an organisation serves unless it is strictly necessary and written into the contribution agreement.
- **Zero tolerance.** Sexual exploitation, abuse and harassment lead to removal from Handova. So does failing to report them.
- **Every need is checked** for safeguarding risk before it opens.
- **Every contribution has a safeguarding focal point**, named by the organisation before work starts.
- **Report within 24 hours.** If someone is in immediate danger, contact local emergency services first. Then use Report a concern or write to safeguarding@handova.org. You do not need proof.
- **We put the person affected first.** Handova acknowledges every report, acts to protect people, involves the authorities where the law requires it and never investigates beyond its competence.
- **The stricter rule applies** where this policy, an organisation's policy or local law differ.

WHO THIS APPLIES TO

- **Professionals** using Handova, from the moment they create an account.
- **Organisations** listed on Handova, everyone in their team who uses it, and every focal point.
- **The Handova team**: today the founder; in future, anyone who works or volunteers for Handova.

It covers everything on Handova, and contact that started on Handova and continued elsewhere.

SECTION 01

Our commitment

Professionals may never meet the people organisations serve, but their work can still affect them. Handova has zero tolerance for abuse, exploitation, harassment or neglect, and for failing to act on concerns. We will:

1. put the safety, dignity and best interests of children and adults at risk first;
2. design the platform so harm is hard to cause: remote work, messages on Handova, no contact, minimal data;
3. review every organisation, profile and need before it is public;
4. make reporting simple for anyone, with or without an account;
5. respond to every concern promptly and fairly, putting survivors first;
6. act against anyone who breaks these standards, and learn from every case.

Principles: best interests of the child; respect for adults' rights and choices (adults are presumed able to decide for themselves); survivor-centred; do no harm, including through our response; inclusion; cultural humility, but culture is never an excuse for harm; proportionality.

SECTION 02

Who we protect: definitions

Child: anyone under 18, whatever the local age of majority or consent. Handova accounts are for people aged 18 and over only.

Adult at risk: a person aged 18 or over who may be less able to protect themselves from harm, abuse or exploitation because of their circumstances, such as disability, illness, age, trauma, displacement, detention, poverty, stigma, or dependence on others, including on the organisation that serves them. Being at risk can be temporary. It does not mean a person cannot make their own decisions.

A professional working remotely cannot judge who is at risk. So Handova uses one simple rule: **treat every person an organisation serves as protected by this policy.** The no-contact and data rules apply to all of them.

WHO AN ORGANISATION MAY SERVE	WHY THE RISK IS HIGHER	WHAT IT MEANS FOR A NEED
Children, including unaccompanied children, children in care, young carers, adolescent girls	Age, dependence, online grooming	No images, names or data about children. No tutoring, mentoring or live sessions with children.
Refugees, asylum seekers, migrants without documents	Legal status, fear of authorities, dependence on aid	No case data. No lists linking names, nationality and location.
Survivors of gender-based violence, trafficking or torture	Trauma, risk from perpetrators, stigma	No identifying testimonies. Never shelter locations. Warn professionals about distressing content.
People with disabilities, including intellectual and psychosocial	Communication barriers, dependence on carers	User research is run by the organisation's staff; results shared anonymised.
People in detention or prison, or recently released	Loss of liberty, power imbalance	No letter-writing or befriending work.
People with serious illness, HIV or mental health conditions; older people needing care	Health data, stigma, dependence	No health records; aggregated figures only.
People in extreme poverty or homelessness	Dependence on help, risk of exchange	No offers of money, jobs or help.
LGBTQI+ people, sex workers, human rights defenders in hostile contexts	Exposure can lead to violence or prosecution	Strict data security; no identifying content.

Other terms. *Abuse or harm*: physical, sexual, emotional, financial or discriminatory harm, neglect or exploitation, in person or online. *Sexual exploitation*: abusing vulnerability, power or trust for sexual purposes. *Sexual abuse*: actual or threatened sexual intrusion by force or under unequal or coercive conditions; for children, including sexual messages or images. *Sexual harassment*: unwanted sexual conduct that violates someone's dignity or creates a hostile or humiliating environment, including between professionals and organisation staff. *Grooming*: building a relationship with someone in order to abuse or exploit them. *Survivor*: the person harmed; we use the term they prefer.

SECTION 03

What this means for needs: contact and data

1. **No direct contact** with children or adults at risk: no messages, calls, video, social media, surveys, interviews, focus groups, user testing, helplines, community groups or meetings.
2. **Anonymise by default.** Professionals work with anonymised or aggregated information.

3. **Identifiable personal data only by exception**, and only if: the work cannot be done without it; the contribution agreement states what data, why, how it is secured and when it is deleted; the organisation may lawfully share it; and the professional sees the minimum, in the organisation's systems where possible, and deletes it at handover.
4. **Never, even by exception:** data or images about children, case files, identity documents, shelter locations, or anything revealing a named person's immigration, detention, health, survivor or sexual orientation status.
5. **No images or stories of children**, and none of adults without the organisation's written consent process.

If a need turns out to involve more contact or data than agreed, the professional stops and reports it, and Handova changes or closes the need.

Handova does not list needs that support orphanage volunteering, visits to residential care for children, or unsupervised contact with children.

SECTION 04

The remote-only rule

Professionals must never:

- contact, befriend or follow on social media anyone an organisation serves, even if they find them online;
- move contact with them off Handova, or give them personal contact details;
- meet them as part of, or as a result of, a contribution;
- ask for, take, keep or share their images, recordings or stories, and never any image of a child;
- run surveys, interviews or tests with them (professionals may design these; the organisation's staff run them);
- show files about them when sharing a screen;
- copy their data to personal devices, personal accounts or AI tools, or keep it after handover;
- offer or accept money, gifts, jobs, sponsorship, migration help or favours, or exchange anything for sex.

Contact with the organisation's own team stays on Handova Messages until both sides have signed, and moves elsewhere only if both want it. Organisations must never ask a professional to break these rules.

If a professional and an organisation choose to meet or work in person, that is outside Handova and under the organisation's policies. Concerns arising from a relationship that began on Handova remain in scope.

SECTION 05

Protection from sexual exploitation and abuse: IASC six core principles

Everyone follows the IASC Six Core Principles relating to Sexual Exploitation and Abuse (2019):

1. **Sexual exploitation and abuse are gross misconduct** and grounds for immediate removal from Handova.
2. **Sexual activity with anyone under 18 is prohibited**, whatever the local age of consent. Mistaken belief about age is no defence.
3. **Exchanging money, work, goods, services or help for sex is prohibited**, including any humiliating, degrading or exploitative behaviour.
4. **Sexual relationships with people an organisation serves that involve improper use of position are prohibited.** On Handova, professionals have no personal contact with them at all.
5. **Anyone with a concern or suspicion must report it.**
6. **Everyone must help keep an environment that prevents sexual exploitation and abuse**, with a particular duty on organisation leaders and the Handova team.

Sexual harassment of anyone, including professionals and organisation staff, also breaches this policy.

SECTION 06

Minimum standards for listed organisations

Every organisation must:

1. **name a safeguarding focal point for each contribution** when signing the contribution agreement: reachable during the work, aware they are named, and not the professional (it can be the signatory);
2. **follow the rules in sections 3 to 5** for every contribution, as agreed in the organisation and contribution agreements;
3. **brief the professional** in the first call on the focal point, how to raise a concern and any rules of its own;
4. **handle concerns properly** under the law, putting the safety and wishes of the person affected first, keeping information confidential and never retaliating;
5. **tell Handova within 24 hours** of any concern connected to a contribution, and promptly about any serious safeguarding incident or investigation involving the organisation;
6. **give the people it serves a way to raise concerns**, and pass any concern about a Handova professional to Handova;
7. **share only what the work needs**, anonymised by default, and never images of children.

At this stage Handova does not ask organisations for their own safeguarding policies.

SECTION 07

How Handova reviews needs

The Handova team approves a need only if every answer is acceptable.

CHECK	ACCEPTABLE
All work is remote	Yes
Any contact with children or adults at risk, including surveys, testing, groups or helplines	No
Identifiable data about people served	No, or a section 3 exception written into the contribution agreement
Images or stories of children, or of adults without consent	No
Output could put people at risk if leaked (e.g. a shelter map, a list of undocumented people)	No, or risk designed out
Distressing content (e.g. testimonies of violence)	No, or flagged in the need
Regulated advice	No, or qualifications and separate terms required
Organisation approved, no open safeguarding concern	Yes

"Design a donor report template" passes. "Mentor teenage girls by video" is declined. "Clean our beneficiary database" needs the data anonymised first, or is declined.

SECTION 08

Vetting proportionate to remote skills work

The main protection is the design of the work: no contact and no identifiable data by default. On top of that, Handova:

- **verifies identity** with Didit (ID document and live selfie) before a professional signs any contribution agreement, showing only an "ID verified" badge;
- **checks LinkedIn**: name, photo and experience must match;
- **collects a signed declaration** of no dismissal or conviction for sexual exploitation, abuse, harassment or offences against children or adults at risk, and no bar or sanctions;
- **may ask for a reference or a short video call** before approving a profile;
- **reviews every profile** before it is public, and again before a closed profile returns.

Why no criminal record checks? These checks are designed for roles with direct contact with children or adults at risk; Handova roles have none, so a check would add little protection. In many countries they are unavailable or not lawful for roles like this, and their quality varies widely between countries.

Collecting them would mean holding highly sensitive data about people worldwide, which is a risk in itself. If a piece of work would need a criminal record check, it is not a Handova need.

Identity checks are not background checks.

SECTION 09

Roles

ROLE	WHO	RESPONSIBILITIES
Safeguarding lead	Julieta Castiñeira de Dios, founder	Owns this policy. Receives and assesses every concern, takes protective action, involves the authorities where needed, keeps the case records.
Independent contact	**to be confirmed soon**	A trusted person outside Handova and Ethical Bridge. Handles concerns about the founder, and covers urgent cases if she can't be reached for more than 48 hours.
Safeguarding focal point	Named by the organisation for each contribution	Receives concerns during the work, acts on them, and tells Handova.
Everyone	All users	Follows this policy, reports concerns within 24 hours, never investigates alone.

If the concern is about the founder, write to the independent contact (**to be confirmed soon**). The founder steps aside from the case and does not see it.

For serious or complex cases, Handova may bring in an external adviser or investigator.

SECTION 10

How to report

If someone is in immediate danger, contact local emergency services first.

- **Signed in:** use Report a concern on the profile, need, conversation or contribution. You get an automatic acknowledgement with a reference.
- **No account:** email safeguarding@handova.org, in English, Spanish, Portuguese or French. You can stay anonymous, though we may then be unable to update you.
- **People served by an organisation:** through its focal point, who passes it to Handova within 24 hours, or directly to safeguarding@handova.org.
- **Professionals** report to the focal point and to Handova, or only to Handova if the concern involves the organisation or focal point.

Report any honest concern. You do not need proof, and you must not investigate.

If someone tells you about harm: listen calmly; tell them they were right to tell you; check they are safe now; write down their words with the date and time; report within 24 hours. Do not ask leading questions, promise secrecy, confront anyone or discuss it with others.

SECTION 11

What happens after a report

This is the procedure for Handova's current stage, with one person handling reports. We will expand it as Handova grows.

1. **Acknowledge.** Reports on the platform get an automatic acknowledgement with a reference. Emailed reports are acknowledged within 2 working days, the same day if someone may be at risk.
2. **Assess and protect.** The safeguarding lead reads the report the same day if it may involve a child, sexual exploitation or abuse, or immediate danger, and otherwise within 2 working days. She takes any protective action needed (section 12) straight away.
3. **Involve the right people.** Where relevant, she tells the organisation's focal point (unless they are involved). She reports to the authorities where the law requires it or someone is in immediate danger, taking care not to put the person affected at greater risk.
4. **Establish the facts** needed for a platform decision: she reads the reported conversation and hears both sides. Handova never runs a criminal investigation; if the authorities investigate, we cooperate and pause our own work if asked.
5. **Decide and close.** She decides the outcome (section 17), tells the person concerned with reasons, tells the reporter as much as confidentiality allows, and records the case. Target: 30 days.

SECTION 12

Protective actions

At any stage, as a precaution and not a finding, the safeguarding lead can: **suspend a person** (profile offline, no messaging, applying or signing); **freeze a conversation** (no new messages, record kept); **take down a need**; **end a contribution** (the professional returns or deletes all information and access); **suspend an organisation**; or **unpublish an impact CV entry** linked to the concern.

SECTION 13

Putting the person affected first

- **Safety first.** Nothing we do should make things worse for them.
- **Their choice.** We explain the options and respect their decisions, unless a child or someone else is at serious risk or the law requires action. If we must act without their consent, we tell them why.
- **Telling it once.** They should have to tell their story as few times as possible. We point them to local help through the organisation where appropriate.

- **Anyone affected**, including professionals exposed to distressing material, can pause or end a contribution at any time.

SECTION 14

For the future

As Handova grows, we will add training for the team and short safeguarding briefings for professionals and organisations, a fuller response procedure, and a list of support services we can point people to.

SECTION 15

Confidentiality, fairness and no retaliation

- Information is shared strictly on a need-to-know basis. Data protection law allows sharing to protect someone from serious harm; it is never a reason not to act.
- The person concerned is presumed not to have done wrong until the facts are established, and can respond.
- Anyone suspended or removed can ask for a review within 30 days. Reviews go to the independent contact (**to be confirmed soon**).
- Retaliation against anyone who reports or helps is a separate, serious breach and leads to removal.

SECTION 16

Records

The safeguarding lead keeps a case record in Handova's restricted admin tools, including reports received by email. Each case records: reference, date and reporter (or "anonymous"); what was reported, in the reporter's words, and about whom; **protective actions**; **who was told**, including any authorities, or why not; the wishes of the person affected; the **decision**, reasons and any review; and the **outcome**.

Only the safeguarding lead, and the independent contact for cases about the founder, can see case records. We keep them for 6 years after the case closes, or longer if legal proceedings are ongoing or expected. Cases involving a child are kept until the child turns 25 or for 6 years after closure, whichever is later. We review them once a year, then delete them securely and log the deletion.

SECTION 17

Outcomes

WHO	POSSIBLE ACTIONS IF A CONCERN IS UPHELD
Professional	Warning, conditions, suspension or removal. Removal takes the profile and impact CV offline, and the same verified identity cannot rejoin.

WHO	POSSIBLE ACTIONS IF A CONCERN IS UPHELD
Organisation	Conditions, needs taken down, contributions ended, suspension or removal; the Ethical Bridge directory is told.
Anyone	Referral to authorities where required.

If a concern is not upheld, access is restored promptly and we review whether anything should change.

SECTION 18

Monitoring and review

- The safeguarding lead reviews open cases every week.
- Each year she writes a short anonymised summary of concerns, outcomes and lessons, kept on file and shared with the independent contact once named.
- This policy is reviewed every 12 months, and sooner when Handova has a team, after a serious incident, a change in law, or a product change affecting contact or data (for example in-person work, live sessions or users under 18).

SECTION 19

Law, standards and related documents

Ethical Bridge LLC is registered in Wyoming, USA, and is subject to US federal and Wyoming law. People take part from many countries, so we also follow the law that applies where they are, including the EU and UK GDPR for personal data. Where rules differ, we follow the one that gives people more protection.

This policy follows the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child, the UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities, the IASC Six Core Principles (2019), the UN Secretary-General's Bulletin (2003), the Core Humanitarian Standard (2024) and the Keeping Children Safe standards (2024).

Related: the other Handova policies (Anti-Harassment, Intimidation and Bullying; Code of Conduct; Data Protection; Fraud, Bribery and Corruption; Whistleblowing; Independent Contact Role Note), the Handova agreements, privacy notice, terms of use and Working responsibly.